



Food Sovereignty Starter Guide

A practical guide to seed saving & food independence

\$8

Open-pollinated • Community-grown • Food sovereignty for everyone

Food Sovereignty Starter Guide

A Practical Introduction to Growing, Saving, and Sharing Seeds

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> "He who controls the seed, controls the food supply. He who controls the food supply, controls the people."

> — often attributed to Henry Kissinger, and worth sitting with regardless of the source

This guide is for people who've started asking questions. Maybe you read something about seed patents and couldn't quite believe it. Maybe you've been thinking about growing your own food but don't know where to start. Maybe you just feel, somewhere in your gut, that the way we grow and distribute food has gone badly wrong — and you want to do something about it that isn't just clicking a petition.

That's exactly why we wrote this.

We're not here to overwhelm you or make you feel like you need five acres and a degree in agriculture. We're here to tell you that growing food, saving seeds, and connecting with others doing the same is one of the most practical acts of resistance available to anyone — including people in apartments, on balconies, and in cities.

Let's start with what's actually happening.

Important Notice

This guide is educational content about food systems, seed saving, and home growing. Your results will vary based on your climate, growing conditions, and local environment. It is not professional agricultural, legal, or financial advice. Use it as a practical starting point and do your own research for decisions that affect your specific situation.

Part One: Why Food Sovereignty Matters

The World's Seed Supply Is Controlled by Three Companies

In 1970, there were thousands of independent seed companies operating in the United States. By 2018, following decades of mergers and acquisitions, roughly **60% of the global commercial seed market** was controlled by just three corporations: Bayer (which acquired Monsanto in 2018), Corteva (formed from DuPont and Dow), and ChemChina (which acquired Syngenta).

This isn't a conspiracy theory. It's documented market consolidation, the same process that turned thousands of local banks into four major ones, or hundreds of airlines into a handful. But when it happens to seeds — the biological foundation of all food — the stakes are fundamentally different.

Here's what concentration at that scale actually means in practice:

Fewer varieties. When a corporation buys a seed company, it evaluates the catalog for commercial potential. Varieties that don't sell in large volumes get dropped. Between 1903 and 1983, roughly **93% of vegetable varieties** that had been commercially available in the U.S. disappeared. The pressures that caused that loss haven't stopped — they've accelerated.

Higher prices. Between 1994 and 2011, the price of soybean seeds in the U.S. increased by **325%**. Corn seed prices rose over **250%** in the same period. A significant driver: the introduction of patented, proprietary traits that farmers must pay licensing fees to use.

Dependency by design. Most commercial seeds sold today are F1 hybrids — first-generation crosses that produce vigorous, uniform plants, but whose offspring don't breed true. A farmer who saves seed from a hybrid crop gets unpredictable results the following year. That's not a bug. It's an engineered dependency. Buy new seed every year, or your harvest suffers.

The Monsanto Story

No discussion of modern seed politics is complete without Monsanto, now absorbed into Bayer but still operating its seed and chemical business under that parent. Here's what they actually did, because it's stranger than most people realize.

In the 1990s, Monsanto developed a line of soybeans genetically engineered to survive applications of their herbicide, Roundup (glyphosate). They called these **Roundup Ready soybeans**. The system was elegant from a business standpoint: farmers could spray entire fields with herbicide, killing weeds but leaving the crop intact. Monsanto patented both the herbicide and the seed trait.

To use Roundup Ready seeds, farmers signed a **Technology Use Agreement** — a contract that explicitly prohibited saving seed from the harvest for replanting. Every year, farmers had to buy new seed from Monsanto. Those who violated the agreement were subject to lawsuits. Monsanto employed investigators to travel rural areas and test farmer fields for the presence of patented traits without a license.

By 2004, **85% of soybeans** planted in the U.S. were Roundup Ready. The patent and licensing structure had, within a decade, reshaped the growing practices of an entire industry.

The Percy Schmeiser Case

Percy Schmeiser was a canola farmer in Bruno, Saskatchewan, Canada. In 1997, Monsanto investigators found Roundup Ready canola growing in his fields. Monsanto sued him for patent infringement.

Schmeiser maintained he had never purchased Roundup Ready seed and had not intentionally grown the patented crop. His position was that the canola had blown onto his land from neighboring farms or passing trucks — a plausible explanation given that canola pollen travels readily by wind and insects. He'd been saving and replanting his own canola seeds for over 40 years.

The Canadian courts ultimately ruled in Monsanto's favor on the core patent infringement question (though Schmeiser was not required to pay Monsanto's legal fees or damages, since he hadn't profited from the trait). The case drew international attention because it illustrated a troubling dynamic: a farmer could be held liable for the presence of patented genetics on his land, regardless of how they got there.

Schmeiser spent the rest of his life as an advocate against corporate seed patents and spoke before the United Nations. He died in 2020. His case remains the most visible example of what happens when seed patents meet the biological reality of how plants actually reproduce and spread.

Why This Matters Even If You Don't Farm

Most of us don't farm. So why does any of this matter to someone growing tomatoes on a fire escape?

Because the logic that concentrates seed ownership in three corporations is the same logic that:

- Determines which crops get research funding (commodity crops, not diverse vegetables)
- Decides which regions get seed access (profitable markets, not subsistence farmers)
- Shapes what food is available in grocery stores (shelf-stable, shippable, uniform)
- Influences what nutrition looks like at a population scale

Food sovereignty — the idea that communities should have the right to define their own food and agricultural systems — is a political claim about who gets to make these decisions. It doesn't require hating corporations. It just requires noticing that the decisions being made by the current system consistently prioritize shareholder returns over biological diversity, farmer autonomy, and food security.

Growing your own food, from seeds you own and can save and share, is a material act of opting out of that system. Even partially. Even on a balcony.

Part Two: What Seeds Actually Are

The Basics, Without the Condescension

A seed is a compressed plant — an embryo with a temporary food supply, wrapped in a protective coat, waiting for the right conditions to begin growing. That's it at the most basic level. But the category "seed" covers an enormous range of genetic diversity, and the distinctions between types matter practically for anyone who wants to save them.

Open-Pollinated Seeds

Open-pollinated (OP) varieties are pollinated by natural means — wind, insects, gravity, whatever the plant uses. The key characteristic is that **seeds saved from open-pollinated plants will grow into plants that closely resemble the parent**. This is what plant breeders call "breeding true."

This matters enormously. If you grow an open-pollinated Cherokee Purple tomato, save the seeds, and plant them next year, you'll grow Cherokee Purple tomatoes. The variety is stable and reproducible. You can grow it indefinitely without buying new seed.

Open-pollinated varieties have been developed over centuries. Many have been selected by farmers and gardeners to perform well in specific regional climates, specific soil types, specific culinary traditions. That embedded information — accumulated through generations of selection — is part of what makes them valuable.

Heirloom Seeds

"Heirloom" is a subset of open-pollinated. The term is used loosely, but generally refers to varieties that are:

- At least 50 years old (some definitions say pre-World War II)
- Open-pollinated and breeding true
- Often associated with specific regions, cultures, or family histories

Heirlooms are not inherently superior to modern OP varieties in every dimension — they often have lower commercial yields, can be more disease-susceptible, and may require more attention. What they offer is **diversity**. Different flavor profiles. Different growth habits. Different adaptations to local conditions. Different histories.

Protecting heirloom varieties is partly about preserving that diversity — biological insurance against the conditions we can't yet predict. A monoculture of high-yield hybrid corn is efficient until a pathogen evolves to exploit it. A diverse landrace of corn varieties is less uniform and less efficient, but survives things that a single-variety field won't.

F1 Hybrid Seeds

F1 hybrids are first-generation crosses between two parent lines that have been carefully inbred to be genetically uniform. Crossing them produces offspring with what breeders call **hybrid vigor** — plants that often outperform either parent in yield, size, or uniformity.

This is why most grocery store tomatoes, peppers, and squash are grown from hybrid seed. Hybrids produce consistent, predictable results, which matters when you're farming at commercial scale.

The problem for seed savers: **seeds saved from F1 hybrids do not breed true**. Plant the saved seeds and you'll get a range of plants expressing different combinations of the grandparent genetics. Some may be vigorous. Many will be mediocre. You won't reliably reproduce the F1 plant you started with.

This isn't magic or corporate trickery — it's basic Mendelian genetics. But it does mean that anyone growing F1 hybrids is dependent on purchasing seed annually. You cannot build a seed collection from them.

If a seed packet doesn't say "open-pollinated" or "heirloom," check the label for "F1" — that designation tells you the variety won't reproduce true from saved seed.

GMO Seeds

Genetically modified organisms (GMOs) involve the direct insertion of genetic material across species boundaries — typically in ways that couldn't occur through conventional breeding or natural pollination. Roundup Ready soybeans are GMOs. Bt corn (engineered to produce its own insecticide) is a GMO. Golden Rice (engineered to produce beta-carotene) is a GMO.

GMO seeds in commercial agriculture are almost universally patented. Their use is governed by licensing agreements. Saving and replanting GMO seed is contractually prohibited and legally actionable.

Beyond the IP issues, GMO crops are not available to home gardeners through normal retail channels. If you're buying from a reputable seed company, you're almost certainly not getting GMO seeds. But the existence of GMO crops in the broader agricultural system creates contamination risks for organic and open-pollinated varieties grown nearby — another reason many seed savers care about this issue.

Why Diversity Matters More Than Yield

Here's the thing about maximizing yield: it works until it doesn't. The Irish Potato Famine of the 1840s killed approximately one million people and forced another million to emigrate. The underlying cause wasn't just a pathogen — it was the fact that virtually all potatoes in Ireland were a single variety (the Irish Lumper), which was devastatingly susceptible to *Phytophthora infestans*. One disease, one variety, catastrophic vulnerability.

Modern agriculture has not learned this lesson as thoroughly as it should. The U.S. grows corn across roughly 90 million acres, with most of it genetically narrow commodity varieties. The banana sold in virtually every grocery store — the Cavendish — is in the process of being threatened by a soil pathogen called Tropical Race 4, following the same arc as its predecessor, the Gros Michel, which was effectively eliminated by a different pathogen in the 1950s.

Diversity is the hedge. Heirloom and open-pollinated seed saving is one of the mechanisms through which that diversity gets maintained.

Part Three: How Seed Patents Work (And Why They're a Problem)

Two Systems: Patents and PVP Certificates

There are two main legal mechanisms through which seed companies protect their varieties in the United States.

Plant patents (under the Plant Patent Act of 1930, extended by the Plant Variety Protection Act of 1970 and subsequent Supreme Court rulings) grant the holder exclusive rights to produce, reproduce, sell, and distribute the protected variety for a term of 20 years. Saving and replanting patented seed without authorization is infringement.

Plant Variety Protection (PVP) certificates offer similar protection specifically for sexually reproduced plants (those grown from seed). PVP-protected varieties include a "crop exemption" — farmers can save seed from their harvest for replanting the following year — but cannot sell or transfer that seed. Research exemptions also apply, meaning breeders can use PVP varieties for breeding purposes.

Standard utility patents, which have been applied to plants since the Supreme Court's 1980 decision in *Diamond v. Chakrabarty* and the 2001 ruling in *J.E.M. Ag Supply v. Pioneer Hi-Bred*, offer the strongest protection: no saving, no replanting, no research exemption without a license.

What "Patented Seeds" Means in Practice

When a corporation holds a utility patent on a seed variety, it means:

- No farmer can save and replant that seed without purchasing a new license.
- No independent breeder can use that variety to develop new varieties without a license.
- No seed library can include that variety in its collection.
- The patent holder can sue anyone who plants that variety without authorization — including farmers who acquired it unintentionally through cross-pollination or seed drift.

The practical effect: independent breeders get locked out. If the most widely planted varieties are all patented, and using them as parent stock for new varieties requires licensing negotiations with large corporations, the pipeline of new open-pollinated varieties shrinks. Public breeding programs at land-grant universities — which historically developed many of the open-pollinated varieties in common use — have been defunded or redirected toward corporate partnerships.

Terminator Technology

In 1998, the USDA and a seed company called Delta and Pine Land (later acquired by Monsanto) patented a technology formally called "Technology Protection System" and informally named "terminator technology" by critics.

The mechanism: seeds are engineered to produce sterile offspring. A plant grown from a terminator seed will produce fruit and seed, but the saved seeds will not germinate. Every generation requires purchasing new seed from the technology holder.

The technology was never commercially deployed — Monsanto announced in 1999 that it would not commercialize it, largely in response to intense international backlash. But the patent existed. The capability was demonstrated. And the underlying business logic — make seed saving physically impossible rather than just legally prohibited — remains an aspiration in portions of the industry.

The dependency created by F1 hybrids (which don't breed true) achieves a similar practical effect without the genetic engineering. The market structure creates the dependency; the terminator seed would just make it harder to escape.

The Open Source Seed Initiative

In 2014, a group of plant breeders, seed companies, and food sovereignty advocates launched the **Open Source Seed Initiative (OSSI)** with a different vision. OSSI varieties come with a pledge rather than a patent: anyone who uses these seeds agrees to make any new varieties developed from them available to others on the same terms. No patents. No restrictions on saving, replanting, or sharing.

OSSI now includes over 450 varieties from dozens of breeders. It's a direct counter-model to proprietary seed systems — an attempt to create a protected commons rather than a protected monopoly.

We think it's one of the most interesting structural interventions happening in the seed world right now, and it's worth supporting with your purchasing dollars.

Part Four: What You Can Do — A Practical Starting Plan

Start Simpler Than You Think You Need To

The instinct, when you start learning about food sovereignty, is to want to do everything at once: grow all your own food, save every variety, start a seed library, rewild your backyard. This is a good instinct pointing at something real. But it's also a reliable path to burnout and a pile of dead seedlings.

Start with one or two plants. Do it well. Save seeds from at least one of them. That's it. That's a meaningful act.

Here's a practical path in for complete beginners.

The Best Starting Crops

Tomatoes — Start Here

Tomatoes are the ideal first seed-saving crop for several reasons:

- They are self-pollinating (the pollen fertilizes the ovary within the same flower before insects arrive), which means cross-pollination between varieties is minimal. Your saved seeds will almost certainly be true to the parent.
- They're easy to grow in containers — a 5-gallon bucket or larger will support a determinate variety.
- The seed-saving process is straightforward and satisfying.
- There are hundreds of heirloom tomato varieties with flavors and characteristics nothing like what you'll find in a grocery store.

Good beginner varieties: Mortgage Lifter (large, meaty, few seeds, historically grown by people to pay their mortgage — literally), Cherokee Purple (complex flavor, deep color), Yellow Pear (prolific, sweet, great for beginners), Brandywine (the classic heirloom standard).

Container growing: Determinate varieties (which grow to a set size and fruit all at once) do better in containers than indeterminate ones. Look for "Patio," "Bush," or "Dwarf" tomatoes for smaller spaces. Use a container at least 12 inches deep, water consistently (inconsistent watering causes blossom end rot), and provide 6-8 hours of direct sun.

Beans — Easy and Reliable

Dry beans and pole beans are among the easiest vegetables to grow and save seed from:

- Like tomatoes, beans self-pollinate before the flower opens, meaning minimal cross-pollination risk.
- Seed saving is as simple as letting the pods dry on the vine and collecting them.
- They fix nitrogen in the soil, improving your growing medium over time.
- Many heirloom varieties have remarkable histories — some have been saved by specific families or communities for generations.

Good beginner varieties: Dragon Tongue (beautiful yellow with purple streaks, good as snap bean or dry), Jacob's Cattle (speckled dry bean, good for storage), Kentucky Wonder Pole (classic, prolific, reliable).

Container growing: Bush varieties grow well in containers 8-12 inches deep. Pole varieties need support (a bamboo trellis or cage) and a deeper container, but are more productive per square foot.

Peppers — Slow but Rewarding

Peppers take longer to get started (they need warm soil and consistent heat) but are very rewarding once they're producing. Like tomatoes and beans, they're primarily self-pollinating, though insects can cause cross-pollination between varieties if they're planted very close together.

Good beginner varieties: California Wonder Bell (reliable, classic), Jimmy Nardello (Italian sweet frying pepper, exceptional flavor), Padron (Spanish tapas pepper, quick to fruit).

Container growing: 3-5 gallon containers work well. Peppers love heat — dark-colored containers on a south-facing balcony can extend the season significantly.

How to Save Seeds from Tomatoes

The tomato seed-saving process involves fermentation, which removes the germination-inhibiting gel coating the seeds:

1. Choose your best fruit. Select from the healthiest plant, from a fruit that represents the characteristics you want (flavor, size, color). Let the fruit ripen fully — past what you'd eat, ideally.
2. Scoop out the seeds and gel into a small jar or cup. Add a small amount of water — just enough to cover. Label it with the variety name and date.
3. Ferment for 2-3 days at room temperature. A layer of mold will form on the surface. This is normal and good — it's part of the process. Stir once a day.
4. After 2-3 days, add a larger amount of water and stir vigorously. Viable seeds sink; dead seeds and pulp float. Pour off the floating material.
5. Rinse the seeds through a fine strainer under running water.
6. Dry thoroughly. Spread seeds on a ceramic plate or glass dish (not paper — they'll stick). Allow to dry completely at room temperature for at least a week. They should snap, not bend, when fully dry.
7. Store. In a labeled envelope or small glass jar. More on storage in Part Six.

How to Save Seeds from Beans and Peppers

Beans: Let the pods dry completely on the plant. When the pods are papery and you can hear the seeds rattling inside, pull the entire plant or pick the pods. Spread in a single layer to continue drying indoors for 2-3 weeks. Shell the beans and store in a cool, dry, dark place.

Peppers: Let the fruit ripen fully — past the point you'd normally eat them. Red, orange, or purple coloration (depending on variety) indicates ripeness. Cut the pepper open, scrape out the seeds, and spread them to dry on a glass or ceramic surface for 1-2 weeks. Stir daily. When fully dry, they'll slide off the surface easily.

Container Gardening Basics

You don't need a yard. Here's what you actually need:

Containers: Larger is better. For tomatoes, 5-gallon minimum; 10-15 gallon preferred. For beans and peppers, 3-5 gallon is workable. Fabric grow bags are inexpensive, excellent for drainage, and can be stored flat in winter.

Soil: Do not use straight garden soil in containers — it compacts badly. Use a quality potting mix (not potting "soil"). Adding 20-30% compost improves moisture retention and nutrition.

Light: 6-8 hours of direct sun is ideal for tomatoes and peppers. Beans are more forgiving. South or west-facing exposures are your best bet in the northern hemisphere.

Water: Containers dry out fast, especially in heat. Daily watering is often necessary in summer. Self-watering containers (with a reservoir at the bottom) reduce this significantly and improve yields. Consistent moisture is more important than any other single factor for container vegetables.

Fertilizer: Container plants exhaust their potting mix nutrients faster than in-ground plants. Feed with a balanced liquid fertilizer every 2-3 weeks once plants are established.

Part Five: Seed Libraries and Community Seed Swaps

What a Seed Library Is

A seed library is exactly what it sounds like: a lending library for seeds. You check out seeds, grow the plants, save seeds from your harvest, and return seeds at the end of the season. The library's collection grows and diversifies as more members participate.

Most seed libraries are run by public libraries, community gardens, food banks, or independent organizations. They're free or very low cost to participate in. They are also one of the most effective distribution mechanisms for heirloom and open-pollinated varieties in communities that might not otherwise have access.

The legal status of seed libraries has been contested. In 2014, the Pennsylvania Department of Agriculture sent letters to libraries suggesting that distributing seeds without proper licensing might violate the state's seed law. The backlash was immediate and bipartisan — gardeners and librarians are not a group that backs down easily — and most of the regulatory pressure receded. But it illustrated that the same legal frameworks designed to regulate commercial seed operations were being used (or threatened to be used) against community sharing.

As of now, seed libraries operate successfully across all 50 states. Some states have passed explicit protections for seed library operations.

How to Find One Near You

- Seed Library Locator at Seed Savers Exchange (seedsavers.org) maintains a directory.
- Search "[your city] seed library" — many public library systems have added seed lending to their services.
- Contact your local community garden — they often know where exchanges happen.
- Farmers markets sometimes host seed swaps, particularly in early spring.

How to Participate

Most seed libraries welcome new participants with open arms and minimal requirements. The general pattern:

1. Register as a member (usually free or very low cost).
2. Check out a packet or two of seed in early spring.
3. Grow the plants, following any instructions for isolation (keeping varieties apart to prevent cross-pollination).
4. Save seeds from healthy plants at season's end.
5. Return seeds to the library — usually more than you checked out, cleaned and labeled.

The key thing to do well when returning seeds: **label accurately and completely**. Include variety name, species, the year grown, and any notes about the plants' behavior (early producer, good disease resistance, etc.). The value of a seed library's collection is directly tied to the quality of its documentation.

How to Start One

If there's no seed library in your area, consider starting one. The barrier is lower than you might think.

The minimum viable seed library is a card catalog box full of labeled seed envelopes at your community garden, library branch, or church. You don't need a database. You don't need a formal organization. You need seeds, envelopes, a box, a sign, and someone who will remind people to return seeds.

Steps for a more formal launch:

1. Find a host. Public libraries are ideal — they already have the infrastructure for a lending system and the community trust. Community gardens, food co-ops, and makerspaces also work well.
2. Gather seed donations. Contact Seed Savers Exchange, OSSl-affiliated seed companies, and local gardeners. Many will donate seed to get a library started.
3. Establish a simple checkout system. A sign-out sheet is enough to start. Library management software (LibraryThing, Koha) can be adapted for seed libraries if you grow to need it.
4. Create return guidelines. How many seeds should be returned? What labeling is required? How do you handle seeds that can't be saved (F1 hybrids, PVP varieties)? Establish these rules early and communicate them clearly.
5. Host a seed swap event. Annual or semi-annual seed swap events build community, introduce new people to seed saving, and replenish the collection. Pair it with a workshop on basic seed saving technique.

Resources: The Seed Library Social Network (now somewhat dormant but still has resources), Seed Savers Exchange's community resources, and the book **Seed Libraries** by Cindy Conner are useful references.

Part Six: Building Your Seed Collection Over Time

Think Like a Librarian

The goal of a personal seed collection isn't to hoard seeds — it's to maintain living variety, year over year, in a way that keeps seeds viable and well-documented. Seeds are not permanent. They have a shelf life. A collection that isn't grown out periodically is a collection that will degrade.

Here's how to think about building and maintaining yours.

Seed Viability: How Long Do Seeds Last?

Different crops have different seed lifespans under ideal storage conditions:

Crop	Approximate Viability
Onions, leeks	1-2 years
Sweet corn	2-3 years
Peppers	2-3 years
Beans, peas	3-4 years
Tomatoes	4-6 years
Squash, cucumbers	4-6 years
Brassicas (cabbage, kale, etc.)	4-5 years
Lettuce	2-3 years

These are guidelines under optimal conditions, not absolutes. Old seed doesn't suddenly stop germinating — it becomes progressively less viable. Test germination rates before planting: place 10 seeds on a damp paper towel in a warm location and count how many germinate after the expected days-to-germination for that crop.

Storage Basics

The enemies of seed viability are heat, humidity, and light. Control these and your seeds will outlast the listed averages.

Cool: The ideal long-term storage temperature is between 35-50°F (2-10°C). A dedicated mini-fridge or the bottom of your refrigerator works well. If refrigerating, ensure seeds are completely dry before sealing — moisture plus cold causes problems.

Dry: Aim for relative humidity below 8% inside storage containers. Commercial desiccant packets (silica gel) added to storage containers absorb moisture. A simple test: seeds should be firm and snap cleanly. If they bend, they have too much moisture.

Dark: Light degrades seed viability over time. Store in opaque containers or in a dark location.

Practical setup for most home seed savers:

- Seed envelopes (coin envelopes work well) inside glass mason jars
- Silica gel desiccant in each jar
- Stored in a cool, dark cabinet or the back of a refrigerator
- Labeled with variety, species, year harvested, and source

Labeling: Do It Immediately and Do It Completely

Seeds that aren't labeled are seeds that are lost, even if they're right in front of you. This sounds obvious but it's the most common mistake in seed saving: "I'll remember." You won't.

Label at the time of harvest. Every packet should include:

- Common name (e.g., Tomato)
- Variety name (e.g., Cherokee Purple)
- Year harvested (viability counting starts here)
- Source (where did the seed come from originally? Your garden? A library? Which seed company?)
- Notes (anything notable about the plant: early fruiting, exceptional flavor, good disease resistance)

A simple template:

Cherokee Purple Tomato

Harvested: 2025

Source: Seed Savers Exchange (initial), my garden (saved)

Notes: Excellent flavor, heavy producer, slight cracking in wet years

Expanding Your Collection

Once you've got the basics down — a few reliable varieties you're growing and saving annually — the fun begins. Here's how to diversify thoughtfully:

Add one or two new varieties per year. Don't try to grow 30 new things at once. Pick one or two varieties you're genuinely curious about, grow them well, learn their habits.

Attend or organize seed swaps. The best way to expand a collection with interesting, locally adapted varieties is to swap with other gardeners in your region. Varieties that someone has been growing in your climate for years are worth more than catalog varieties that have never seen your conditions.

Join Seed Savers Exchange. Their member listings give you access to thousands of varieties maintained by individual gardeners. You can request seed from members who list varieties they're willing to share. The annual Yearbook is a catalog of member-maintained varieties — it's remarkable browsing.

Keep a garden journal. Track what you grew, how it performed, what you saved, and what you'd grow again. Over years, this becomes invaluable. Memory is not a reliable backup.

Isolation Distances

If you're growing multiple varieties of the same crop and want to save pure seed, you need to be aware of cross-pollination and plan accordingly.

Self-pollinators (minimal cross risk): Tomatoes, beans, peas, lettuce. These can be grown in close proximity with very little risk.

Wind/insect pollinators (require separation): Corn, brassicas (kale, cabbage, broccoli — they all cross with each other freely), squash, cucumbers, melons. In a small space, you can generally only save from one variety of each of these per season.

Brassicas are particularly tricky. Kale, cabbage, kohlrabi, broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower, and collards are all the same species (*Brassica oleracea*) and will cross freely. If you want to save seed from kale, don't let any other brassica flower that year, or expect a genetic mash-up in your saved seeds.

For small space growers, the practical answer is: **stick to self-pollinators for seed saving**, and when you want to branch out into wind/insect-pollinated crops, save from only one variety of each at a time.

Part Seven: Resources and Next Steps

Organizations Worth Supporting

Seed Savers Exchange

seedsavers.org

The largest heirloom seed preservation organization in the U.S. They maintain over 20,000 varieties at their Heritage Farm in Decorah, Iowa. Their seed catalog is a starting point for most serious seed savers. Member participation — through the Yearbook listing system — is one of the most effective community seed preservation mechanisms in existence. Annual membership is \$40 and includes the Yearbook.

Native Seeds/SEARCH

nativeseeds.org

Based in Tucson, Arizona, with a focus on seeds of the American Southwest and northern Mexico — crops with deep cultural roots in indigenous and traditional farming communities of the region. They maintain over 1,900 varieties. Particularly strong collection for anyone interested in drought tolerance, arid-climate growing, or traditional Southwestern crops (tepary beans, Hopi blue corn, many chile peppers).

Open Source Seed Initiative (OSSI)

osseeds.org

The freedom-pledge model for seeds described in Part Three. Their catalog of pledge varieties continues to grow. Supporting OSSI-affiliated seed companies is a direct way to fund open-pollinated plant breeding.

Organic Seed Alliance

seedalliance.org

Advocates for organic seed production and conducts organic plant breeding research. Good resources on seed saving for farmers and gardeners at a more technical level.

Southern Exposure Seed Exchange

southernexposure.com

Worker-owned cooperative seed company specializing in varieties suited to the Southeast U.S. but carrying excellent collections across all regions. Strong on heirloom varieties, rigorous on open-pollinated standards.

Books Worth Reading

"Breed Your Own Vegetable Varieties" by Carol Deppe

The best introduction to home plant breeding we know of. Not just seed saving — actual breeding: making crosses, selecting for traits, developing your own varieties. More accessible than the title implies.

"Seed to Seed" by Suzanne Ashworth

The comprehensive reference for seed saving. Crop-by-crop coverage of isolation requirements, harvest timing, cleaning methods, and storage. If you're going to own one seed saving book, this is the one.

"The Seed Underground" by Janisse Ray

A personal, literary account of seed saving culture in the American South. Part memoir, part manifesto, part guide. Reads like the knowledgeable friend we described at the start of this guide.

"One Straw Revolution" by Masanobu Fukuoka

A Japanese farmer's account of farming in harmony with natural systems, written as a philosophical memoir. Not a how-to manual, but one of the most influential books in sustainable agriculture thinking. Worth reading.

"Farmers of Forty Centuries" by F.H. King

A 1911 account of agricultural practices in China, Korea, and Japan — systems that had sustained dense populations for thousands of years without soil degradation. It's free online (public domain) and deeply informative about how to think about soil as a living system.

What to Grow First

If you've read this guide and you're ready to start, here's our suggested first season:

One tomato: Start with Mortgage Lifter or Cherokee Purple. Get a single 5-gallon container, a bag of good potting mix, and a packet of seed. Start indoors 6-8 weeks before your last frost date.

One bean: Dragon Tongue bush bean or Kentucky Wonder pole bean. Direct sow after last frost, one seed per inch, thinned to 3-4 inches. Needs almost nothing from you.

One thing you're personally curious about. The food sovereignty movement isn't just about practical production — it's about reconnecting with the diversity of what food can be. Pick something you've never tasted, something with a history, something that sounds interesting. Grow it because you want to know what it is.

Save seeds from at least one of these plants.

Share what you grow.

A Final Note

None of what we've described here is complicated. People grew food and saved seeds for ten thousand years before seed patents existed, before GMOs, before any of the current machinery of corporate agriculture. The knowledge was held locally, passed between neighbors, stored in ceramic pots and paper envelopes and the memories of the people who used it.

Some of that knowledge was disrupted. But it wasn't destroyed. It's in the seed libraries and the Seed Savers Exchange member listings and the hands of gardeners who've been quietly maintaining varieties through decades of corporate consolidation.

Every seed you save is a small act of memory. Every seed you share is a small act of trust.

That's what food sovereignty actually looks like — not a political program, not a brand, but a practice. Something you do with your hands, in whatever space you have, alongside other people doing the same.

We're glad you're here.

— Seedwarden

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